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Much as we'd like them to be, movie DVDs still aren't cheap. If you have a lot of them lying around, you probably value them dearly, and are worried about them getting scratched. Then there's the issue of friends borrowing them and not returning them! In general, it's a good idea to back up your DVDs. And no, just trying to copy the VOB files to your hard disk won't do it!

Here we tell you how to back up a DVD movie and convert it to the popular DivX formats—you can then burn them back onto DVD. And yes, it's legal—just as for CDs, it's legal to have one backup of a DVD. Once you create backups, with the movies in DivX format, you can cram three or even four of them onto a DVD! There's a whole bunch of software required to do this, but after you've done it for one movie, it will become routine. So here's the list:

1. **DVD Decrypter:** This is a very fast and free DVD ripping software. It can rip multi-angle DVDs. Find it at www.mrbass.org/dvdrip/SetupDVDDecrypter_3.5.4.0.exe. The current version is 3.5.4.0, and it's a 0.86 MB download.

2. **DVD2AVI:** You use this software to convert the ripped and decrypted VOB files to the AVI file format. DVD2AVI v1.77.4 is freeware, and is available at www.afterdawn.com/software/video_software/dvd_rippers/dvd2avi.cfm. The download is a tiny 0.16 MB.

3. **DivX Create:** This has a software codec that allows you to compress videos while maintaining almost the same quality as that of the original video. The latest version of is 6.2, and is available at www.divx.com. It is

15-day trialware (\$19.99, or Rs 950, for the registered version), and the download is 16.4 MB.

4. **LAME ACM MP3 audio codec:** This MP3 codec is required for compressing and encoding audio to a bitrate of 128 kbps, which is good enough for most purposes. Windows comes with an MP3 codec, but this doesn't allow encoding to a bitrate higher than 56 kbps, which is way too low. You can download the LAME ACM MP3 codec from www.free-codecs.com/download/LAME_ACM_Codec.htm. Just 214 KB.

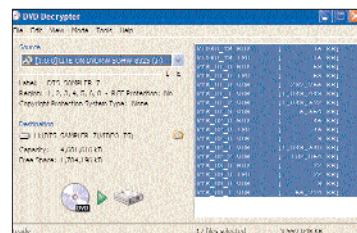
5. **VirtualDUB:** A video capture/processing utility for 32-bit Windows. Freeware. It is very fast, and is used to create DivX videos. The latest version is 1.6.14, and can be downloaded from www.virtualdub.org. It's about a 1 MB download.

Armed with this arsenal of tools, let's rip those DVDs!

A) Insert your DVD into the drive and launch DVD Decrypter. DVD Decrypter will detect the DVD, and its file contents will be displayed in the right pane. Now go to **File > Browse** and select the destination for the ripped VOB files. Keep in mind that the destination must have enough free space to store the contents of the entire DVD.

After choosing the destination, click on **File > Decrypt** to start the decryption process. DVD Decrypter removes the Macrovision protection (which is a type of copy protection in video DVDs) by default, and you can set it to remove the region code as well by going to **Tools > IFO > Region Patch > Region Free**. These are necessary for the next step. After the DVD ripping process is completed, close DVD Decrypter.

B) Next, launch DVD2AVI. Go to **File > Open**. Make sure the correct track number in the Audio menu is selected. You need to find the correct track number—



The DVD Decrypter main window

most DVDs have multiple audio tracks in different languages. This can be checked by selecting one track at a time and playing it. Also click on the Audio menu and navigate to "48 > 44.1 KHz", and select Off. Go to **Help > SIMD Technology** and select all the optimisations supported by your processor. Now go to **File > Save as AVI**.



Choose the appropriate bit rate for your movie

Decide on a file name and choose a location with enough free space. You will now be prompted to choose a video compressor. Choose "DivX 6.2.1" from the drop-down menu where you can select the video compressor.

Under the Certification Profiles, you can choose an appropriate preset profile such as High Definition, Home Theatre, Portable, Handheld, and

